

# CHAPTER 6

## MARIAM'S NAME IS THROWN IN

*'I will slap her.'*

Anil, the police constable who had first warned me of the bugging device in the room, stood there. 'Tea or coffee, sir?' he said, and I replied just 'yes'. I don't remember what he brought. I sipped the lukewarm drink, unable to taste it. Every bit of my body was paining. The joints were virtually immovable; the ache made me feel each and every muscle in my body.

'They've all left,' said Anil. 'Do you want anything?'

I asked for a newspaper. I asked for an English newspaper since I couldn't read Malayalam. Anil said I would not find anything about the spy case in the English newspapers—it was the forte of the Malayalam papers, this juicy developing story that made every rookie reporter an investigative journalist who unearthed a hidden strategy of espionage or equally important, the favourite positions of the Maldivian women in bed.

Two men came into the room. 'Get dressed.'

I was in the same old brown shirt and trousers that I wore from home to the Vanchiyoor police station on 30 November 1994. It had been five days. I stood up, unsteady. When Anil came to support me, the men abused him. 'You think he is your grandpa?' they shouted. Anil scurried out.

One of the men told me the CBI was coming to interrogate me. Later, I came to know from some of the other accused that the IB men, before handing them over to the CBI, had asked them to repeat the tale they were